YAMUNA PAR AZADI KA AMRIT MAHOTSAV
An Event to Remember

Yamuna Par Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav was celebrated on the banks of the Yamuna in Delhi on August 16 and saw the launch of several key initiatives of the Ministry of Jal Shakti.

The 'Yamuna Par Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav' organised by National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG), Department of Water Resources, River Development and Ganga Rejuvenation (DoWR, RD & GR), Ministry of Jal Shakti on August 16 was an event to remember, not only for the spectacular festivities and activities, but also for the slew of initiatives of the Ministry of Jal Shakti that were showcased and launched there.

Most importantly, it showcased the Hon. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision for a clean Yamuna, the Ganga's biggest tributary, which thanks to the efforts of NMCG, is visibly cleaner even near major urban centres like Delhi.

The event took place at Zero Pushta, Sonia Vihar along the Yamuna in Delhi. It was presided over by Shri Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, Hon. Union Minister of Jal Shakti and held in the presence of Shri Pankaj Kumar, Secretary, DoWR, RD & GR, Ministry of Jal Shakti, Shri G. Asok Kumar, Director General, NMCG and Shri Ganji K.V. Rao, Director General, Tourism, Ministry of Tourism.

After arriving, Shri Shekhawat unfurled the Indian flag and the National Anthem was played by the BSF band. The Hon. Minister then took a boat tour on the Yamuna with the jawans of National Disaster Response Force, observed a kayaking demonstration, and planted trees.

The occasion marked the launch of several initiatives under Arth Ganga, a concept initiated by PM Modi to get the river-people connect through the economic bridge to ensure sustainability of activities under 'Namami Gange', the flagship programme of the Government to clean the Ganga and its tributaries.

Initiatives launched by Shri Shekhawat included Jalaj, an MoU with Sahakar Bharti for natural farming, and the tourism-related portal ImAvatar. Shri Shekhawat interacted with local convenors of Jalaj, a river tourism initiative he virtually launched at 26 locations. While encouraging the Jalaj participants, he also emphasized the work that needs to be done. One of ImAvatar's biggest offerings is the digital pooja facility along the Ganga's ghats. On the occasion of 'Yamuna Par Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav', 75 priests on a boat off Varanasi's Assi Ghat offered a live pooja during the event.

Addressing the gathering, Shri Shekhawat said that while India reveres its rivers it is also true that our water bodies and rivers are getting contaminated. It is, therefore, imperative to keep them *Aviral* and *Nirmal*, and called for a people's movement to make it possible. "Let's transform *Jal Andolan* into a *Jan Andolan* to keep our rivers clean," he said.

Referring to the Hon. Prime Minister's speech on the occasion of Independence Day, Shri Shekhawat said: "The Hon. Prime Minister emphasized the sacrifices made by the leaders and today after 75 years we have reached a pedestal where the world looks at us with respect." He praised NMCG's initiatives and emphasized the importance of river-based tourism. Shir Shekhawat also pointed out the new focus on cleaning and reviving the Ganga's tributaries.

Talking about the rejuvenation of the Yamuna, Shri Pankaj Kumar, Secretary, DoWR, RD & GR, said that operation of Coronation Pillar STP has already started in Delhi, while the operation of 3 big STPs is also targeted to be completed by December.

Shri G. Asok Kumar, Director General, NMCG, while congratulating everyone on the historic occasion of 75 years of Independence, said that building a nation in the true sense is not possible without honouring and preserving the most significant gift of nature—the Rivers. The rivers holistically have had cultural, economic and spiritual significance since time immemorial, he added.

